EXCURSION RISK MANAGEMENT — WATER-BASED ACTIVITIES

Water-Based Excursion Risk Management Template

Victorian Secondary Schools · Aligned to DE Excursion Policy · Swimming & Water Safety Education Policy

PART A — Excursion Details

SCHOOL NAME

EXCURSION TITLE

DATE(S) OF EXCURSION

YEAR LEVEL(S)

NUMBER OF STUDENTS

VENUE / LOCATION NAME

FULL ADDRESS (FOR 000 PURPOSES)

TEACHER IN CHARGE (TIC)

TIC MOBILE NUMBER

VENUE EMERGENCY CONTACT

TYPE OF WATER ACTIVITY

Beach swim / Pool swim / Kayaking / Snorkelling / River / Other: _____

WATER ENVIRONMENT

Patrolled beach / Unpatrolled beach / Pool / River / Dam / Lake / Other

IS THIS A PATROLLED VENUE?

Yes — lifeguard provided / No — school provides supervision

PART B — Supervision Arrangements

Always verify current DE supervision ratios before submitting. Reference: www2.education.vic.gov.au/pal/swimming-instruction-and-water-safety-education/policy

Role	Name	Qualification	Contact on the day
Teacher in Charge (TIC)			
Supervising Teacher 2			
Supervising Teacher / Adult 3			
Lifeguard / Instructor (venue)		*Current lifeguard cert.*	
Designated Water Watcher		Role: scan the water continuously. No other tasks. Rotate every 15–20 minutes.	
First Aider		*Current first aid cert.*	

TOTAL SUPERVISING ADULTS

STUDENT:ADULT RATIO

RATIO MEETS DE REQUIREMENT? (CIRCLE)

Yes / No — escalate to principal

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PART C — Student Information & Medical Considerations

Consideration	Number / Detail	Management strategy
Non-swimmers		Coloured cap identification. Shallow-end / shore supervision only. Buddy assigned. All supervisors briefed.
Weak/beginner swimmers		Identified with coloured caps or wristbands. Restricted to waist-depth maximum. Water Watcher priority monitoring.
Students with asthma		Inhaler location confirmed. TIC briefed. Avoid cold water entry stress. Spare inhaler at first aid station.
Students with cardiac conditions		Medical clearance confirmed. AED location known. Cold water entry monitored. TIC briefed.
Students with epilepsy		Buddy assigned at all times in water. Lifeguard briefed on condition. Emergency protocol confirmed.
Students with other conditions		
Consent forms received		All forms on file at school office and copy with TIC. Students without consent cannot participate in water activities.

STUDENTS WITH SPECIFIC RESTRICTIONS (LIST BY NAME AND RESTRICTION):

PART D — Hazard Register & Risk Controls

Risk level: **HIGH — eliminate or substitute before proceeding**

MEDIUM — control required, document mitigation **LOW — monitor and manage**

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Hazard	Likelihood (1–5)	Consequence (1–5)	Risk Level	Control measures in place
Drowning / near-drowning		5	HIGH	Patrolled venue OR qualified lifeguard on deck; Water Watcher assigned; non-swimmers identified; buddy system; all supervisors CPR trained; AED accessible
Cold water shock (inland / open water venues)		4	MEDIUM	Water temperature assessed pre-excursion (do not proceed below 15°C for school groups). Students enter water gradually. Cold water shock symptoms briefing delivered. First aider on site.
Rip currents (beach venues)		5	HIGH	Patrolled beach between flags only. Students briefed on rip identification and escape. BeachSafe conditions checked morning of excursion. No unpatrolled beach entry permitted.
Watercraft collision (kayaking / paddling)		4	MEDIUM	Lifejackets (PFDs) worn at all times on water. Paddle Australia safety briefing delivered. Designated launch and exit zones. No paddling in vessel traffic areas.
Slip / fall on wet surfaces		3	MEDIUM	No running on pool deck/jetty. Non-slip footwear required at pool venues. Students briefed on walk-only rules. Wet surfaces inspected pre-session.
Diving into unknown/shallow water		5	HIGH	Feet-first entry rule enforced at all venues. Depth posted at all entry points. "No diving" sign/instruction given at start of each session. Zero tolerance enforced.
Sunburn / heat stress (outdoor venues)		2	LOW	Sunscreen applied pre-activity. Hats and rashvests available. Shade access during non-swimming time. Hydration encouraged. Heat management plan if >35°C.
Marine stingers (beach venues)				Check SLSA/BeachSafe for marine life alerts. Purple flag = do not enter. Vinegar at first aid station (for jellyfish stings). Review current conditions day-of.
Student separation /		4	MEDIUM	Buddy system in place. Head counts every 10 minutes. Designated meeting

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missing student				point communicated to all students. Check-in/out protocol at all entries and exits.
Medical emergency (non-drowning)			**MEDIUM**	First aid kit on site. Trained first aider present. 000 dial protocol: venue address confirmed before departure. Nearest hospital: _____
Additional hazard (site-specific):				
Additional hazard (site-specific):				

PART E — Emergency Procedures

Emergency Type	Procedure
Drowning / near-drowning	1. Signal lifeguard immediately (whistle/shout). 2. Water Watcher calls 000: state venue address — " [fill in address] ". 3. Clear all other students from water. 4. Begin DRS ABCD. 5. Send person to entrance to direct ambulance. 6. Notify school administration. 7. Document everything.
Missing student	1. Immediate head count. 2. Assign adults to search zones. 3. One supervisor stays with remaining students. 4. If not located within 5 minutes: call 000 and notify school principal immediately. 5. Do not leave venue.
Serious injury (non-drowning)	1. Assess danger. 2. Call 000 if life-threatening. 3. Apply first aid — do not move casualty unless in danger. 4. Notify school administration. 5. Contact parent/carer. 6. Complete incident report same day.
Medical emergency (anaphylaxis, cardiac)	1. Call 000 immediately. 2. Administer EpiPen if anaphylaxis and student is prescribed one. 3. AED location: _____. 4. Begin CPR if unresponsive and not breathing. 5. Stay with student until ambulance arrives.
Severe weather / lightning	1. Clear water immediately at first thunder or lightning sighting. 2. Move all students to the designated shelter: _____. 3. Do not re-enter water until 30 minutes after last lightning. 4. If shelter is unavailable, remain in vehicles or low-lying area away from trees.

VENUE ADDRESS FOR 000:

NEAREST HOSPITAL:

SCHOOL PRINCIPAL MOBILE:

PART F — Pre-Excursion Compliance Checklist

- [ ] DE Excursion Policy reviewed and current version confirmed
- [ ] Principal approval obtained and documented

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- [ ] All student consent forms collected and on file
- [ ] All student medical forms reviewed — restrictions and conditions noted in Part C
- [ ] Supervision ratios confirmed to meet DE requirements (Part B)
- [ ] Qualified lifeguard confirmed for venue (or school providing equivalent qualified supervision)
- [ ] Designated Water Watcher role assigned and briefed
- [ ] First aid kit checked and stocked; first aider qualified and present
- [ ] AED location at venue confirmed and operational
- [ ] Venue address confirmed for 000 purposes — written on TIC's phone/paper
- [ ] Nearest hospital/medical centre confirmed and route known
- [ ] Non-swimmers and restricted swimmers identified and informed supervisors
- [ ] Coloured caps or wristbands arranged to identify non-/beginner swimmers
- [ ] Students have received water safety briefing (or will receive at venue)
- [ ] Students have signed the student safety acknowledgement (use Carnival Briefing sheet)
- [ ] Weather forecast checked — proceed criteria confirmed
- [ ] BeachSafe / venue conditions checked (for beach venues) morning of excursion
- [ ] Lifejackets (PFDs) available and fitted (for kayaking/paddling excursions)
- [ ] Transport arrangements confirmed — bus/vehicle supervision included
- [ ] School administration has full copy of this risk management document

PART G — Conditions for Proceeding & Contingency Plan

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Condition	Proceed threshold	Contingency if threshold not met
Weather	No thunder/lightning forecast. Wind below 30 km/h for water activities. Temp above 15°C for open water.	Classroom-based water safety theory lesson (use student workbooks). Reschedule within term.
Surf / water conditions (beach)	Patrolled beach conditions acceptable to lifeguard on duty. No red-only flag. No rip current active in swimming zone.	Move to alternative patrolled beach confirmed in advance. Or substitute pool activity. Do not proceed at unpatrolled beach.
Supervision ratios	Full required supervision ratio met. Lifeguard confirmed on site.	Do not proceed without required adult ratios. Contact school for relief staff. Reschedule if unresolvable.
Venue availability	Venue confirmed open, lifeguard on duty, and water quality acceptable.	Backup venue: _____ (confirm in advance)
Water temperature (inland venues)	Water temperature at or above 15°C (below this triggers cold water shock risk for school groups).	Substitute pool-based activity. Do not enter cold open water with school group. Document decision.

BACKUP / CONTINGENCY ACTIVITY IF EXCURSION CANNOT PROCEED:

PART H — Approval & Sign-Off

TEACHER IN CHARGE — SIGNATURE

DATE APPROVED:

ASSISTANT PRINCIPAL / YEAR LEVEL COORDINATOR

DATE APPROVED:

PRINCIPAL — FINAL APPROVAL

DATE APPROVED:

POST-EXCURSION NOTES / INCIDENT RECORD (COMPLETE WITHIN 24 HOURS OF RETURN):

Policy References: This template is designed to support compliance with DE policy. Always verify current requirements before use.
Department of Education Swimming and Water Safety Education Policy: www2.education.vic.gov.au/pal/swimming-instruction-and-water-safety-education/policy
DE Excursions Policy: www2.education.vic.gov.au/pal/excursions/policy
Life Saving Victoria: lsv.com.au · Paddle Australia (kayaking/paddling): paddle.org.au · BeachSafe (conditions): beachsafe.org.au

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